



#### ▲ Humans and their world

Created by or in imitation of the 17th-century Swiss artist Matthäus Merian, this anthropomorphic landscape can be turned on its side to reveal a human face. Links between humanity and the natural world were important to philosophy, and disguising forms to explore philosophical allegories was a popular artistic pursuit.

Unlike occult philosophers, natural philosophers made advances in protoscience (emergent forms of science, such as experiments in alchemy that formed the basis of chemistry)—although they did not always differentiate it from natural magic or pseudoscience (information claimed to be scientific, which proves not to be when judged by the values of modern mainstream science). Much of their work laid the foundations for the Enlightenment and the modern scientific revolution; but some is now part of the history of the occult arts.

#### Living in harmony

The work of Paracelsus illustrates the intersection of protoscience with pseudoscience and natural magic. This Swiss astrologist, alchemist, physicist, chemist, and physician was a major figure in both medical science and early chemistry, but also held views consistent with occult philosophy. He drew on Hermetic belief, Kabbalah, and Rosicrucianism, and made important inquiries about humanity's place in the universe. Such ideas, often cloaked in complex allegory, can be seen in the era's artworks,

#### Fact and fiction

There are historical overlaps between magic, protoscience, and pseudoscience, because natural philosophers, occult philosophers, and alchemists treated their work as a serious investigation of the universe. Some approached the truth, at least in part. For example, it is actually possible to turn lead into gold, as the alchemists hoped (see pp.148–151), but it is misleading to explain this, as they did, in terms of the zodiac or the movement of celestial bodies.

Religion, too, played a role in the story of pseudoscience and protoscience, being a vital ingredient in magical thought (particularly the definition of natural magic). In contributing to such thinking, it also helped foster the early development of natural science.

“Magic has power to experience and fathom things which are inaccessible to human reason. For magic is a great secret wisdom, just as reason is a great public folly.”